

The Architecture of Scent

The fragrance pyramid, the olfactory families, and how a scent unfolds rather than simply exists

Learning Objectives

- Explain the fragrance pyramid and how a scent evolves across top, middle, and base notes
- Identify the major olfactory families used in bridal and event fragrance work
- Explain concentration tiers and sillage, and how each shapes a fragrance's presence
- Explain why fragrance structure is the foundation every other skill in this course depends on

A scent is not one note. It is a story unfolding.

Every skill this Atelier has taught you — skin in Course I, hair in Course II, colour in Course III, the hand in Course IV, touch in Course V, ceremony in Course VI — has trained a single sense at a time: sight, mostly, and touch. This course trains an entirely different one. Scent behaves nothing like colour or texture; it changes over hours, reveals itself in stages, and is remembered differently by every nose that encounters it. Understanding that structure is the foundation everything else in this course is built on.

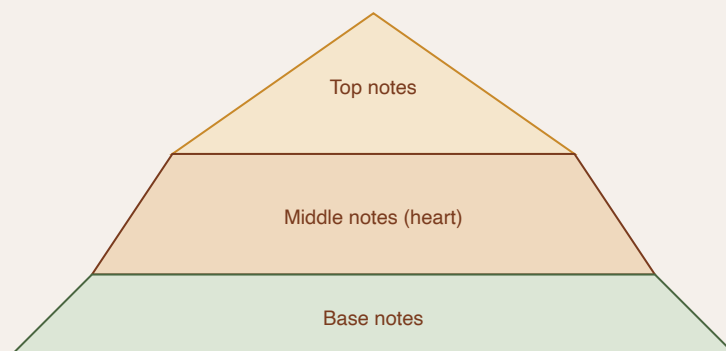
A fragrance is not applied and finished. It is applied and begun — the story it tells over the next eight hours is the actual product you are offering a client.

The fragrance pyramid

- **Top notes.** The first impression, lasting roughly fifteen minutes to half an hour — typically citrus, light florals, or fresh green notes, chosen to be immediately pleasant but not the fragrance's true character.

- **Middle notes (the heart).** Emerging as top notes fade and lasting one to two hours — typically florals, spices, or fruit, and usually considered the fragrance's genuine identity.
- **Base notes.** The longest-lasting layer, unfolding over several hours — typically woods, musks, resins, and ambers, and what remains on skin or fabric long after the top and middle notes have gone.

◆ Figure 1.1 · The Fragrance Pyramid



Fifteen minutes, two hours, then the rest of the day — three different fragrances in one bottle, in sequence.

The olfactory families

Most fragrances are classified into a small number of broad families: Floral (rose, jasmine, and similar single or blended flower notes), Woody (sandalwood, cedar, vetiver — warm and grounding), Oriental/Amber (resins, spices, vanilla — rich and warm), Fresh/Citrus (bergamot, lemon, green notes — light and bright), and Chypre (a mossy, earthy base often paired with citrus top notes). Learning to place any fragrance you encounter into one of these families is the fastest route to matching a scent confidently to a client's stated preference.

Concentration and sillage

Concentration — the proportion of aromatic compound to alcohol and water — determines strength and typical wear time: parfum (roughly 20–30%) lasts longest, eau de parfum (roughly 15–20%) is the common bridal choice, eau de toilette (roughly 5–15%) is lighter, and eau de cologne (roughly 2–4%) is the lightest and shortest-lived. Sillage — the scent trail a fragrance leaves in the air around a person as they move — is a separate quality from strength on skin, and Module Six will teach you to manage it deliberately.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

Practical Activity · Build a Scent Story

For a hypothetical bridal client, select one top note, one middle note, and one base note that together tell a coherent "scent story," and explain your reasoning for each choice.

Keep this exercise. It is the first page of your capstone portfolio in Module Fifteen.